

■ By Kaveree Bamzai

Akshay Kumar is sitting at the head of his dining table, the king of his castle, a Rs 4-crore luxury apartment with a private garden and his very own road running into a still pristine part of Juhu Beach. He's watching his five-year-old son Aarav tuck into his tandoori chicken, having discreetly slipped a methi ki roti on his plate as well, and says solemnly: "The other day I was putting money into the safe and told my son this is what I have earned today. And do you know what he said? 'Yes, dadda, I know you are a worker, not a robber'."

Quite. Ever since his first movie was released in 1991, at a screening watched by his parents and 30 relatives from his home in Delhi's Chandni Chowk, where his 93-year-old grandmother still lives, Kumar has been a worker. He's acted in 110 films so far, been written off at least four times, and now, at almost 40, he's one of the most saleable stars in Bollywood, whose last four films (*Phir Hera Pheri*, *Jaane-Mann*, *Bhagam Bhag* and *Namastey London*) have made over Rs 180 crore at the box office and whose current film, the Rs 37-crore *Heyy Babyy*, has already grossed Rs 15 crore in the first week. In the next six months, the star who now has three major endorsements (Thums Up, Grasim and Xbox) is threatening to make the never-before-imagined transition to grade A actor as well—playing a spooked hero in Nagesh Kukunoor's *8x10*; a cook-cum-kung fu master in Nikhil Advani's Warner Bros co-production *Made in China*, a film written for him (a clear mark of having arrived); a Kanpur-se-aya action hero in Yash Raj Films's *Tashan*; and a clean-shaven Sikh who becomes a ganglord in Anees Bazmee's caper *Singh is Kinng*.

So how did Kumar morph from Mr Muscles with the Mickey Mouse voice into an all-rounder star, a sort of Jackie Chan-meets-Jerry Lewis? How did the former photographer's assistant and sometime-Bangkok-cook-of-samosas-and-jalebis get to a point where he now makes Rs 8 crore a film? How did the actor who cried in a bathroom because he had to take his shirt off in *Waqt Hamara Hai* do a virtual striptease in *Heyy Babyy*? How did the man who had a reputation with the ladies, manage to marry a no-nonsense working woman from Bollywood royalty (she's the daughter of Rajesh Khanna and Dimple Kapadia) and keep it going?

Hard work and a whole lot of reinvention. He wakes up at 5 in the morning every day, works out on his current fancy (at present, it is the cross-training sport, parkour, and no, he's never done weights), and sleeps by 10.30. He doesn't drink (his buddy director Vipul Shah says he once forced him to

drink a glass of white wine on a flight to South Africa and he woke up only when he reached Cape Town) and doesn't smoke. Instead, he reads scripts, listens to narrations and, more importantly, works 10 hours a day. Says Advani: "Once he commits to do a film, he's with it body, heart and soul. If you call him, he will pick up the phone himself." Such is his clockwork timing that he would reach the sets of *Mujhse Shaadi Karogi* at 7 a.m., forcing late-rising co-star Salman Khan to sleep over in his vanity van. One of the last Bollywood heroes to work double shifts, he too now sticks to one film at a time, preferring not to work like a taxi on hire and behave like the racing car he's become. More than that, he doesn't have cronies or campsters, and likes to keep his entourage slight (by Bollywood's bloated standards, a secretary, a manager, a spot boy and a trainer is almost Gandhian in simplicity). More than that, his home revolves around things more important than the star's ego—such as whether the napkins are starched, the iPod has been fixed and the booking at his wife's favourite restaurant, Taj's Wasabi, been made.

It's not been easy. The 6'1" star, after all, got into acting only because it seemed an attractive way of making money. "I was making Rs 5,000 a month as a martial arts instructor. The first time I was on a modelling assignment, I got Rs 5,000

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From naff to neon bright, from desi to dude, the actor has become more than eye candy in action. With his last four films making more than Rs 180 crore at the box office, the 110-film old star has been reborn.

for just standing in the studio for a day with a beautiful girl. I thought this is the life," he says. The man who would end up playing every sort of character in Bollywood (villain in *Ajnabee*, dramatic hero in *Andaaz* and comic Lothario in *Mujhse Shaadi Karogi*) became an actor, almost, notes long-time buddy Sajid Nadiadwala, silently—Nadiadwala and Kumar would travel by the same bus (No. 255, supplies Kumar promptly) to Don Bosco school in Mumbai. Nadiadwala was a couple of years senior and their paths would cross later. Kumar stayed in the B-list of action wasteland, repeatedly called a piece of furniture by critics ("They were kind," he now says, "I was an entire showroom.") until he was rescued by Tanuja Chandra's *Sangharsh* in 1999. The film wasn't a success but Kumar was noticed as more than beefcake for the first time. Then followed a series of films which marked his slow ascent, ending with the most recent *Namastey London*, where his orange-haired, pink-kurta clad

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